

IN CONTEXT

The Three Choirs Festival

Founded in 1715 and still flourishing today, the Three Choirs Festival rotates annually between Hereford, Gloucester, and Worcester cathedrals. It has provided great opportunities for music-making on a scale rarely seen in the English provinces.

From 1878 to 1893, the young Elgar played violin in the orchestra each time the festival was held in Worcester Cathedral. Many of his early works were written to be performed at successive festivals, including the Froissart overture (1890) and the cantatas *The Black Knight* (1893) and *The Light of Life* (1896).



WORCESTER CATHEDRAL,
NORTHWEST VIEW, 1836

Edward Elgar was born in 1857 in the village of Broadheath, outside Worcester, in the West Midlands. His family were of the modest lower-middle class. His father ran a music shop in Worcester, played the organ at a local church, and tuned pianos.